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It's Junk, And It's On Your PC

BRAD STONE OF *Newsweek* magazine tells us why the humble PC is a sucker for junkware.

Last spring Amy Fenollosa's brand-new Dell laptop morphed into an unruly ad-blasting machine. As she watched helplessly, her screen filled over and over with pop-up promotions for travel deals, cheap mortgages, pornography and—in a bitter twist—tools to help her get rid of unwanted ads. “The pop-ups came incessantly,” she says. “I couldn’t even open the Web browser or restart my computer. It made me crazy.” She brought the laptop to two computer stores before a tech rep at Best Buy finally wiped her hard drive clean and told her to start from scratch.

Call it whatever you want: adware, spyware, malware or junkware, but it's wrecking the online experience for millions of computer users. Adware loads itself onto the desktop,

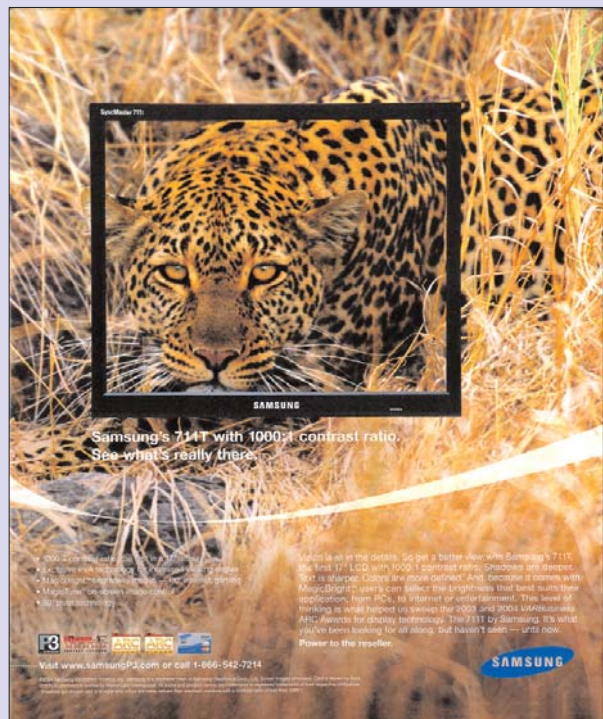
sometimes secretly, and can slow a computer to a crawl and fight the user's best efforts to uninstall it. Last October, AOL and the nonprofit National Cyber Security Alliance reported that 80 percent of home computers were infected with adware. It's the new spam; frustrating, time-consuming and even destructive when it opens the digital door to more serious vermin like viruses or spyware-software that can steal personal info like credit-card numbers. The Feds are now taking action. Last fall the Federal Trade Commission sued a Web-site operator for sneaking adware onto user's machines. Next year Congress will likely finalize a bill requiring adware companies to alert users when software is being downloaded and clearly tell them how to remove it. "Adware makes the Internet a riskier place and undermines confidence in it," says Thomas Pahl of the FTC.

Unlike spammers, shady operators who often reside overseas, profitable U.S. companies pioneered and dominate the adware industry. When it filed to go public earlier this year, Silicon Valley-based Claria reported annual profits of \$35.6 million on revenue of \$90 million (it later withdrew the offering). Evidently, mainstream advertisers, such as Orbitz and American Airlines, pay well for their ads to appear right on the screen, often at the moment a user begins researching vacation plans.

With new regulations on the horizon, adware firms are now scrambling to clean up their act. This fall, Bellevue, Wash., adware firm 180solutions appointed a “chief compliance officer” to oversee its business practices. Last April, the once-secretive New York firm DirectRevenue raised \$20 million from Insight Venture Partners, a well-known venture-capital firm that has Google CEO Eric Schmidt on its advisory board. DirectRevenue CEO Joshua Abram says he is now committed to having “clear relationships” with consumers, branding all of his ads and making it easy for users to uninstall his software.

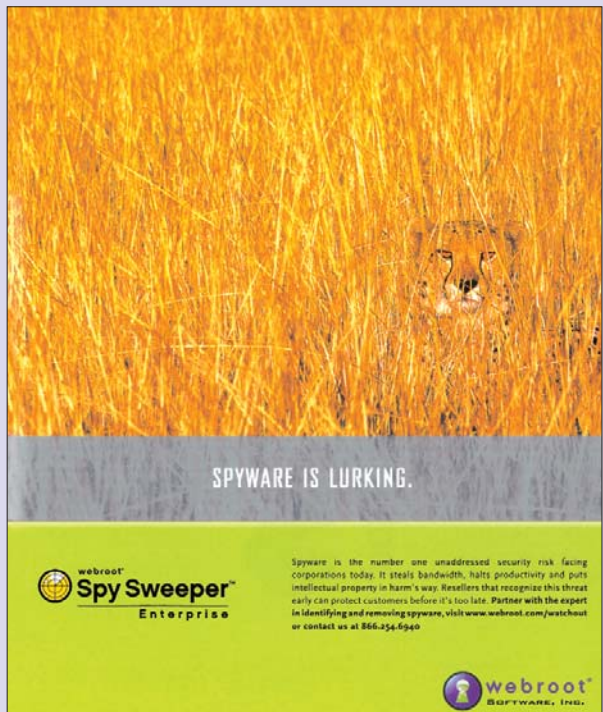
But a review of DirectRevenue's business practices reveals some of the challenges that adware firms face. To get its software onto 20 million computers, DirectRevenue has violated several of the provisions being considered in the proposed laws. The majority of its pop-ups contain no obvious sign that they come from DirectRevenue, and its adware is often difficult to uninstall. Abram points to his site, MyPCTuneup.com, which will remove the adware. But pointers to that Web address are buried deep inside the multiple user license agreements (ULA) users can peruse when they download free software like a screen saver, which contains DirectRevenue's adware. The ULA also warns consumers not to remove the software with anti-spyware tools or it will reinstall itself.

The full article is at <http://snipurl.com/digitpc>



The Samsung Safari!

Remember, if you want to avoid becoming dinner when on your African safari, you need to carry your Samsung 17-inch LCD with you!



The Hunt Is On

Keeping with the big cat theme, this advertisement does well to bring out the camouflage and spying properties of spyware. Get yourself a spyware cleaner... Now!